

THE LOST KINGDOM
A pensive Rahul Gandhi

THE DISINTEGRATION OF TEAM RAHUL

These leaders were often projected in the media as members of the young team the Gandhi scion was building



AJAY MAKEN
Still one of Rahul's most trusted men. Now a CWC member and general secretary in-charge, Rajasthan



SACHIN PILOT
UPA minister and ex-Rajasthan Congress president; now leading the dissent against CM Ashok Gehlot



JITENDRA SINGH
CWC member and general secretary in-charge for Assam. Restricted to his constituency since 2014



MILIND DEORA
The UPA minister has not won an election since 2014; remains disgruntled



MEENAKSHI NATARAJAN
One of Rahul's young picks. Missing since the second Lok Sabha defeat in 2019

EXIT DOORS →



JYOTIRADITYA SCINDIA
A UPA minister, he lost in 2019. Joined the BJP after toppling the Congress government in MP



ASHOK TANWAR
A Rahul favourite, he was Haryana state president; left in 2019, joined the TMC in 2021



R.P.N. SINGH
UPA minister had not won an election since 2014; latest to join the BJP



JITIN PRASADA
A UPA minister, he was one of the G23 dissidents; joined the BJP in 2021



SUSHMITA DEV
Daughter of Santosh Mohan Dev, she was made chief of the party's women wing; joined the TMC in 2021

Gandhi in August 2020 seeking an overhaul of the party organisation and leadership, has not been given any significant assignment despite being a senior leader in the Lok Sabha. Only Maken and Jitendra Singh have shown unwavering commitment to Rahul though they too have not won a single election since 2014.

Apart from the original team, down the years, Rahul also backed several other young men and women, giving them significant roles in the party. A 38-year-old Ashok Tanwar, who was also a former Youth Congress president, was made president of the Haryana Congress. Sushmita Dev, daughter of Gandhi family loyalist and former Union minister Santosh Mohan Dev, was made head of the All India Mahila Congress. Both joined the Trinamool Congress (TMC) last year. Though none of the breakaway leaders has publicly uttered a word against Rahul, sources attribute their disillusionment to the latter's leadership style and the failure of the party to come up with a narrative that can attract voters.

Privately, many complain that the Congress leader can be 'flighty', periodically changing his advisors and promoting a new coterie while others fall off the radar. Also, once he turns his back on someone, it becomes very difficult to get an audience again. After losing patience, and trust, with many, Rahul now doesn't rely on the counsel of any particular leader and has adopted what one leader describes as a horses-for-courses approach. "This is making his decisions seem more random. One day he is consulting Jairam Ramesh, the next K.C. Venugopal. A party decision can even be made after a casual conversation with someone from another party, like CPI(M) general secretary Sitaram Yechury. This is making his own leaders restless," says a CWC (Congress Working Committee) member.

Rahul's supporters dismiss such criticism and claim "the deserters" moved because they couldn't even protect their own constituencies. "The